

On personal articles in Chilean Spanish*

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Abstract

This paper investigates personal articles, i.e., definite articles that combine with personal names in referential contexts, in Chilean Spanish. This syntactic pattern has been widely characterized in other Spanish varieties as expressive or pragmatically marked. Drawing on quantitative evidence from previous corpus studies, acceptability judgments, and morphosyntactic diagnostics, the paper argues that personal articles in Chilean Spanish have a fundamentally different grammatical status. Unlike in other varieties, they neither encode discourse anaphora nor convey interpersonal proximity. The paper advances an analysis according to which Chilean Spanish speakers command two alternative sets of rules for personal names: a conservative Pan-Hispanic (sub)grammar that generates bare personal names, and an innovative and more productive (sub)grammar with which personal names surface with overt definite articles. The optionality of personal articles is thus argued to result from grammar competition rather than from choice of specific forms within a single and unified grammatical system.

Keywords— personal articles, expressivity, proper names, Chilean Spanish

1 Introduction

Human-denoting proper names, also referred to as *personal names*, are standardly analyzed as inherently definite nominal expressions. As such, they generally resist combination with definite articles.

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- (1) (*The) Cosmo came early.
 (2) (*ha)-Yahweh, (*ha)-David, (*ha)-Ya'akov
 the-Yahweh the-David the-Jacob
 'Yahweh, David, Jacob'

Hebrew (Gesenius 1909: §125.2)

Despite this generalization, some languages display what are commonly known as *personal articles*. These are definite articles that combine directly with personal names in *referential* uses, i.e., in cases in which the name serves to pick out a unique, specific individual. Modern Greek is a well-known example of a language with personal articles.

- (3) Érchetai *(o) Dimítris
 comes the Dimitris
 'Dimitris comes.'

Modern Greek (Guardiano 2011: 192)

Personal articles should be distinguished from cases where definite articles combine with personal names used in a *predicative* fashion (e.g., Burge 1973, Schoubye 2017). In predicative uses, the name does not identify a unique individual directly, but rather denotes a class of individuals. In such cases, personal names behave like common count nouns and thus combine with a wide range of determiners, including definite ones. Definite articles in these contexts make their standard semantic contribution: they restrict the denotation of the nominal expression to a contextually salient individual or set of individuals. Such predicative uses arise, for instance, when personal names are modified by adjectives or (restrictive) relative clauses, or when they contain plural morphology.

- (4) a. This is not *(the) Elaine I know.
 b. I meant *(the) tall Jerry, not the short one.
 (5) George and Ringo joked that *(the) Johns often argued over lyrics.

In what follows, I will focus on “bare” configurations such as (3), where a definite article combines directly with a human-denoting proper name in the absence of any restrictive modifier or plural morphology. Predicative uses of the kind illustrated in (4) and (5) fall outside the scope of this discussion, as the appearance of a definite article in those contexts is (i) independently motivated and (ii) widely available across languages (Matushansky 2006).

There are languages that appear to license personal articles optionally, i.e., they allow but do not require the combination of a definite article with a personal name. The presence or absence of the article does not alter the truth-conditional meaning of the sentence: both variants pick out the same individual and make the same contribution to propositional content. This pattern is attested, for instance, in certain varieties of Brazilian Portuguese (Sedrins 2017: 240).¹

- (6) a. (O) João saiu cedo.
 the João left early
 'João left early'.

¹Andrés Saab (p.c.) has pointed out to me that the alternation in (6) is largely restricted to northeastern Brazilian dialects; in most Portuguese varieties, the definite article is generally obligatory.

- b. Ela gosta do/de João.
 she likes of.the/of João
 ‘She likes João.’

The combination of a definite article and a personal name is also optionally attested in several varieties of Spanish. This pattern has been documented primarily in non-standard registers across a wide range of countries, including Argentina (e.g., Vidal de Battini 1964), Chile (e.g., Oroz 1966), Ecuador (e.g., Toscano Mateus 1953), the Dominican Republic (e.g., Henríquez Ureña 1940), Peru (e.g., Kany 1945), and Spain (e.g., Millán Gómez 2023), among others.

- (7) (La) Camila confía en (el) José.
 the Camila trusts in the José
 ‘Camila trusts José.’

The literature has consistently characterized personal articles in Spanish as carrying expressive meaning. Several authors have proposed that the article contributes some form of speaker-oriented evaluation, although the precise nature of this contribution has largely remained unclear. Thus, Vidal de Battini (1964) notes that the personal article in Argentina most frequently carries a pejorative and disqualifying meaning, although she acknowledges that these values vary across regions and contexts. In Costa Rican Spanish, the personal article has been described as introducing a negative or disrespectful tone (Arroyo 1971). Similarly, Jorge Morel (1978) notes that the use of the article before personal names in Santo Domingo Spanish conveys annoyance or a pejorative attitude. For Colloquial Old Spanish, Calderón Campos (2015) reports a range of nuances related to closeness and subjective evaluation. In Mexican Spanish, the construction has been argued to trigger a range of readings, including deprecation and affection toward the referent (Carranza Brito 2008). Taken together, these descriptions converge on the view endorsed by the *Nueva Gramática de la Lengua Española* (RAE & ASALE 2009: 219–220): personal articles are affective rather than discriminative in nature. I adopt this consensus as a working generalization: personal articles in Spanish trigger expressive interpretations.

Yet characterizing personal articles as merely “expressive” or “affective” leaves the nature of that contribution underspecified. Oggiani & Aguilar Guevara (2024) address this lack of precision by arguing that the semantic contribution of the personal article in Spanish is better understood in terms of *interpersonal proximity*. On this view, the article conveys that the speaker feels a close relationship with the referent of the proper name. This relationship may be either positive or negative, and thus can range from affection or admiration to irritation or dislike; the notion thus straightforwardly accounts for the well attested variation in evaluative interpretations of personal articles across Spanish varieties.

In this paper, I discuss the properties of personal articles in a specific Spanish variety: Chilean Spanish. I advance two main theses. First, I argue that personal articles in this variety instantiate a formal and grammar-driven pattern rather than an expressive option, which sets Chilean Spanish apart from other Spanish dialects in which the construction is linked to interpersonal proximity. At first sight, this claim appears to be in tension with the fact that personal articles are optional in Chilean Spanish as well. This tension is resolved by my second claim: Chilean Spanish speakers have two alternative sets of grammatical rules for personal names, one requiring the presence of the article and the other not. I contend that this “diglossic” system gives rise to surface optionality, with the rules that require the article functioning as the default. The analysis draws on quantitative data from previous studies, as

well as on novel data from acceptability judgments collected informally from students at Universidad Austral de Chile in a classroom setting (two groups of around thirty students each).

The structure of the paper is as follows. Section 2 introduces the empirical background for the discussion of personal articles in Chilean Spanish, including their basic distribution and quantitative data from the literature that support the claim that Chilean personal articles differ from similar phenomena found in other dialects. Section 3 evaluates the adequacy for Chilean Spanish of two explanations proposed for personal articles in other varieties: that they function as anaphoric markers and that they encode expressive meanings towards the referent of the name, i.e., interpersonal proximity; both possibilities are rejected based on acceptability judgment data provided by Chilean Spanish speakers. Section 4 develops the grammatical analysis of the construction in Chilean Spanish by stating the rules that give rise to personal names with and without the definite determiner. Section 5 contains the conclusions.

2 Some background on Chilean Spanish personal articles

2.1 Basic distribution of the pattern

Personal articles are attested in several Romance languages, though with varying degrees of obligatoriness and pragmatic effects, e.g., Catalan (Bernstein et al. 2019), Portuguese (da Cunha & Cintra 2016), Venetian (Brunelli 2007), Trentino (Rabanus 2023), French (Kleiber 1981); see Cornilescu (2025) for a brief comparative discussion. Spanish, as illustrated in (7) above, is also among them. Before examining the Spanish pattern in detail, however, it is worth establishing a baseline for how personal names typically behave in the language. Fernández Leborans (1999) identifies three prototypical uses: referential, vocative, and denominative (i.e., in so-called *naming contexts*). In all three, the personal name standardly appears bare, i.e., without any determiner.

- | | |
|--|---|
| <p>(8) a. Cosmo vino temprano.
 Cosmo came.3sg early
 ‘Cosmo came early.’</p> <p> b. ¡Ven aquí, Juan!
 come.2sg here Juan
 ‘Come here, Juan!’</p> <p> c. Me llamo María.
 REFL call.1sg María
 ‘I am called María.’</p> | <p><i>referential</i></p> <p><i>vocative</i></p> <p><i>denominative</i></p> |
|--|---|

Fernández Leborans also identifies non-prototypical uses in which the name picks a predicative role and behaves syntactically as a common noun. He illustrates with the examples in (9); these cases are analogous to the predicative uses previously exemplified for English in (4) and (5) and thus will not be considered further.

- (9) a. Ya no eres el Juan que yo conocí.
 already not are.2sg the Juan that I knew.1sg
 ‘You are no longer the Juan I knew.’

- b. Tengo un Óscar en mi grupo.
have.1SG a Óscar in my group
'I have an Óscar in my group.'
- c. Dice que ha conocido varias Paulas.
says.3SG that has met several Paulas
'He says he has met several Paulas.'
- d. No hay Enriques en la lista.
not are Enriques in the list
'There are no Enriques on the list.'
- e. No parece haber María que se le resista.
not seems.3SG to.be María that REFL 3SG.DAT resists.3SG
'There seems to be no María who can resist him.'
- f. Se cree un Cela.
REFL thinks.3SG a Cela
'He thinks he is a Cela.'

Except for contexts like those in (9), personal names normally reject the definite article (Leonetti 1999). Nonetheless, personal articles have been attested in colloquial registers in several Spanish varieties, where they are known to carry strong connotations of familiarity, affection or disdain; see Laca (1999: 924), Fernández Leborans (1999: 112–113), Martínez (1999: 2717), and Bosque & Gutiérrez-Rexach (2009: 262), among others, for succinct mentions of these properties. Laca (1999) notes that greater tolerance for the article is observed with hypocoristics (nicknames and shortened forms of proper names), whose inherently familiar connotations may facilitate the appearance of the article. She also notices that notable exceptions to the description offered so far are varieties influenced by contact with Catalan or Portuguese, in which the phenomenon appears to be more general. Beyond these observations, however, the literature has little more to say about the grammatical properties of personal articles in Spanish.

Chilean Spanish offers a useful starting point for a more systematic investigation. To begin with, personal articles are licensed in this variety in a wide range of syntactic positions and grammatical functions. Personal names introduced by a definite article may appear as subjects, e.g., (10a), direct objects, e.g., (10b), indirect objects, e.g., (10c), or complements of prepositions, e.g., (10d). In all these cases, personal names are used referentially.

- (10) a. El Vicente llegó temprano.
the Vicente arrived early
'Vicente arrived early.'
- b. La Carolina saludó al Vicente.
the Carolina greeted DOM.the Vicente
'Carolina greeted Vicente.'
- c. Le dimos la tarjeta al Vicente
3SG.DAT gave the card DAT.the Vicente
'We gave the card to Vicente.'
- d. Confiamos en el Vicente.
trust in the Vicente

‘We trust in Vicente.’

There are, however, two well-defined contexts in which personal names categorically reject overt determination in Chilean Spanish. The first corresponds to Fernández Leborans’s vocative use, e.g., (11a). The second corresponds to his denominative use: contexts in which the name is used to assign or introduce a label for an individual, e.g., (11b).²

- (11) a. (*La) Ana, acuérdate de cerrar la puerta.
 the Ana remember of close the door
 ‘Ana, remember closing the door.’
 b. Yo me llamo (*la) Ana.
 I REFL.1SG call the Ana
 ‘I am called Ana.’

The ban on personal articles in vocative and denominative contexts is attested not only in Chilean Spanish, but also in other Spanish varieties. The same is independently observed in languages that require personal articles across the board such as Modern Greek, e.g., (12). This suggests that the patterns in (11a) and (11b) are part of a more general restriction rather than an idiosyncratic property of Chilean Spanish.³

²As noted by Alejandra Bastías (p.c.), nicknames are sometimes acceptable in naming contexts in this variety.

- (i) A mí me dicen el Flaco.
 DAT 1SG 1SG.DAT call.3PL the skinny
 ‘They call me Skinny.’

Most likely, uses like (i) involve a reanalysis of the definite article as part of the nickname.

³As discussed in González López (2019) and references therein, vocatives generally reject the presence of determiners.

- (i) (*Los) chicos, vayan a comer.
 the kids go.3PL to eat
 ‘Kids, go eat.’

In principle, the restrictions attested in (11a) and (12) could be subsumed under this more general pattern. This solution is not without problems, however. An immediate difficulty is that definite determiners are acceptable in vocatives in so-called *identificational uses*, i.e., cases in which a vocative singles out an addressee from a larger group of potential addressees (Schaden 2010), e.g., (ii) and (iii).

- (ii) El chico de la última fila, salga al estrado.
 the kid of the last row go.out.3SG to.the stage
 ‘The kid in the back row, step up to the stage.’ (González López 2019: 136)
(iii) Băiatu’, ți-a căzut ceva!
 boy-the CL.2S.DAT-has fallen something
 ‘Boy! You dropped something!’ Romanian (Croitor & Giurgea 2024)

In contrast, personal articles in Spanish remain unacceptable in vocative contexts even when the intended use is identificational. The exact nature of the restriction on personal articles in vocatives therefore remains a question for future research.

- (12) a. O Yanis vaftistike (*o) Petros.
the Yanis baptize.PASS the Petros
'Yani was baptized Petro.' *Modern Greek (Matushansky 2006: 286)*
- b. (*I) Maria, na grafis prosektika.
the Maria NA write.2sg carefully
'Maria, write carefully.' *Modern Greek (Stavrou 2014: 332)*

In Chilean Spanish, personal articles are compatible with a broad range of name types. They are attested with given names, e.g., (10), surnames, e.g., (13), a combination of both, e.g., (14), shortenings, e.g., (15), diminutives, e.g., (16), and nicknames, e.g., (17). This distribution contrasts sharply with that of other varieties, such as Rioplatense Spanish, where personal articles tend to appear mostly with nicknames (De Mello 1992).

- (13) El Milei está más loco que la cresta.
the Milei is more crazy that the crest
'Milei is crazy as hell.'
- (14) Ese weón de ahí es el Cristián González.
that dude of there is the Cristián González
'That dude over there is Cristián González.'
- (15) ¡Llamemos a la Vicky!
call DOM the Vicky
'Let's call Vicky!'
- (16) ¡El Gonzalito está super contento!
the little.Gonzalo is.3sg very happy
'Little Gonzalo is very happy!'
- (17) El Care'Churrasco se había quemado la cara con una línea de vapor a presión.
the face.of.beef SE had burned the face with a line of steam to pressure
'Beef-Face burned his face with a line of high-pressure steam.'

In most Spanish varieties, the use of a definite article with personal names is considered substandard and is typically associated with rural speech, substandard registers, or slang. This characterization does not extend to Chilean Spanish. In fact, the pattern can be regarded as the default option in this variety. As Oroz (1966: 371, my translation) puts it: "the use of the article with proper names in Chile is not limited to rustic or vulgar speech, but can be considered almost a general norm." This type of observation is not confined to the linguistic literature. The *Real Academia Española* (RAE) has publicly acknowledged the divergence of Chilean Spanish in this respect. In a Twitter post from 2023, reproduced in Figure 1, the RAE stated that, with the exception of Chilean Spanish and the Spanish spoken by Catalan bilinguals, the use of definite articles with personal names is generally considered nonstandard or vulgar. The post went viral in Chile and was picked up by the national news. This suggests that the distinctiveness of the Chilean pattern is well-known to its own speakers.

As can be seen, there is already a widespread sense that the use of definite articles with personal names in Chilean Spanish differs from what is found in other varieties. In the following sections, I will show that this intuition is correct, and that personal articles in Chilean Spanish must be set apart from superficially similar phenomena in other dialects.



Figure 1: RAE on personal articles in Spanish.

2.2 Frequency of the pattern in Chilean Spanish

Several quantitative studies have examined the frequency of personal articles across different varieties of Spanish. As will be shown in this section, the resulting frequency patterns reveal sharp contrasts suggesting that the Chilean Spanish version of the phenomenon differs qualitatively from those varieties in which personal articles function as expressive markers.

One of the earliest quantitative studies on the topic is De Mello (1992), who measured the frequency of definite articles preceding personal names in the speech of educated speakers across ten Spanish-speaking cities. The study reports a total of 135 instances of the construction. The distribution of these instances across cities is summarized in Table 1.

The table reveals a clear stratification among the surveyed cities. In several locations, such as La Habana, Lima, Sevilla, and Mexico City, no instances of the construction were attested. A second group of cities exhibits only marginal use of personal articles, with one or a few occurrences in the corpus; this is the case of Bogotá, San Juan, and Madrid. In contrast, the pattern appears substantially more productive in Buenos Aires and Caracas, where the number of attested examples increases markedly. Finally, Santiago de Chile stands out sharply from all other locations, accounting for the vast majority of the occurrences of personal articles in the corpus: 98 out of 135. This highly asymmetrical distribution suggests that the use of personal articles in Santiago is not merely a low-frequency expressive pattern, but a distinct and highly productive grammatical trait of Chilean Spanish.

As illustrated in the examples in (13) to (17), Chilean Spanish displays personal articles with a wide range of personal name types. As shown in Table 2, also from De Mello, other varieties are considerably more selective. In the Santiago de Chile sample, personal articles occur not only with given names, but also with diminutives, nicknames, surnames, and full names. By contrast, the remaining varieties display either very low frequencies across the board or a marked concentration on one or two

City	Examples	City	Examples
La Habana	0	Sevilla	0
Lima	0	C. de México	0
Bogotá	1	San Juan	1
Madrid	3	Buenos Aires	15
Caracas	17	Santiago	98

Table 1: Frequency of personal articles across Spanish-speaking cities (De Mello 1992)

specific types of personal names.

City	Given name	Dim.	Nickname	Surname	Full name
Bogotá	0	0	0	0	1
Buenos Aires	1	0	10	2	2
Caracas	6	0	0	8	3
Havana	0	0	0	0	0
Lima	0	0	0	0	0
Madrid	2	0	0	1	0
Mexico City	0	0	0	0	0
San Juan	0	0	0	1	0
Santiago	53	11	15	3	16
Seville	0	0	0	0	0
Total	62	11	25	15	22

Table 2: Personal articles with different types of names (De Mello 1992).

Further evidence for the widespread use of personal articles in Chilean Spanish comes from a study by Tieperman (2018, *apud* Tieperman 2020), based on contemporary media data. Analyzing several episodes of the Chilean television series *Casado con hijos*, Tieperman reports that out of 746 tokens of human-referring proper names, 54.6% are realized with a definite article. This result is consistent with the trend emerging from De Mello’s (1992) study.

In a later study, Tieperman (2020) and Tieperman & Regan (2023) examine the factors governing the use of personal articles in three speech communities, Santiago de Chile, Mexico City, and Granada, using data from the PRESEEA corpus. The distribution of personal articles across these cities is summarized in Figure 2. As the figure shows, Santiago displays a markedly higher proportion of realizations of personal names with definite articles, accounting for 70.2% of the tokens, while the remaining cases involve bare proper names. In contrast, speakers from Granada and Mexico City overwhelmingly favor bare realizations, with personal articles occurring only marginally in Granada (10.8%) and being virtually absent in Mexico City (2.6%).

The authors also observe a striking contrast between Granada and Santiago de Chile with respect to the distribution of personal articles across social classes. As shown in Table 3, while upper-class speakers from Granada categorically avoid the use of personal articles, upper-class speakers of Chilean Spanish still produce them in more than 50% of the cases. This sociolinguistic contrast provides an additional rationale for the asymmetry between Chilean Spanish and other varieties attested in Table 1,

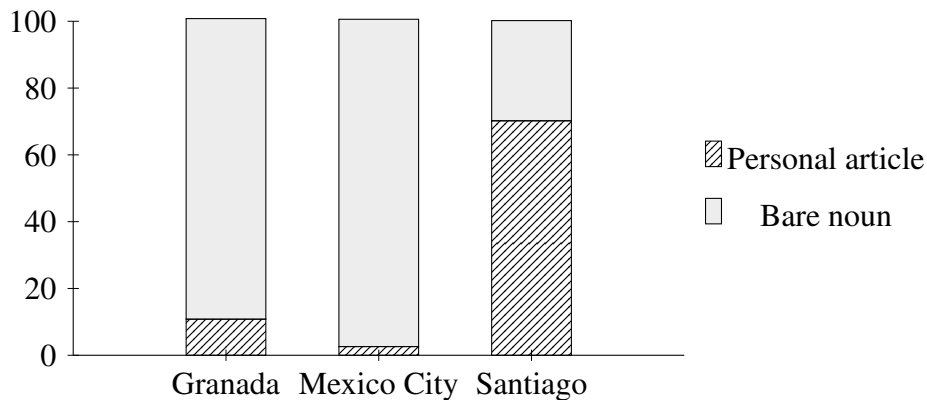


Figure 2: Personal article use in three Spanish varieties (Tieperman 2020).

since De Mello’s data were drawn from educated, arguably upper-class, speakers who tend to avoid personal articles, unlike upper-class speakers in Chile.

City	Lower	Middle	Upper
Santiago	68.1	74.9	53.8
Granada	17.9	19.0	0.0
Mexico City	4.2	4.3	1.6

Table 3: Personal article use by social class in three Spanish varieties (Tieperman 2020).

Further quantitative evidence comes from Hunt (2021), who conducted a corpus study of definite article use preceding personal names across eight Spanish-speaking countries (Argentina, Chile, Colombia, Cuba, Mexico, Paraguay, Peru, and Spain) using the *Corpus del Español: Web/dialects* (Davies 2016), a written corpus of over two billion words drawn primarily from blogs and other webpages. The analysis was based on over 350,000 tokens drawn from the 98 most frequent Spanish given names. An important limitation of the study is the written nature of the corpus: since personal articles are consistently characterized in the literature as a feature of spoken Spanish, a written corpus can be expected to substantially underrepresent the phenomenon relative to its actual frequency in everyday speech. Despite this limitation, the results are revealing on two counts. First, colloquial article use was attested in all eight country datasets, which confirms that the surface pattern is not exclusive to Chilean Spanish but is present, at varying frequencies, across the Spanish-speaking world. Second, and consistent with the studies reviewed above, Chile emerged as the country with by far the highest rate of article occurrence, at 1.49%, more than double the rate of any other country in the study. That this result held even in written data suggests that the Chilean preference for personal articles is robust enough to surface across registers.

A further issue that has been investigated quantitatively, but that will not be central to the argument developed in this paper, concerns a contrast between male- and female-referring names in the use of personal articles. Oroz (1966: 371, my translation) noticed over sixty years ago that omitting the personal article “sounds affected when dealing with feminine names,” while “masculine proper names are sometimes used with the article and sometimes without it.” This observation translates into a tendency: personal articles are more common with feminine personal names than with masculine ones.

This asymmetry has been corroborated by De Mello (1992) and replicated across multiple studies (Tieperman 2018, 2020, Aliaga Rovira et al. 2020, Tieperman & Regan 2023, Garrido-Sepúlveda et al. 2024), although the picture that emerges from modern data is less clear-cut than what Oroz originally suggested.⁴

This type of gender sensitivity is not uncommon in the syntax of personal articles cross-linguistically. In Venetian, for instance, Brunelli (2007: 12) characterizes the use of personal articles as characteristic of feminine personal names, which leads to contrasts such as *go visto Mario* ‘I saw Mario’ vs. *go visto la Maria* ‘I saw Mary.’ The pattern is reversed in Flemish dialects of Dutch, where Van Langendonck (2007: 158) observes that the definite article is systematic before men’s names but only optional before women’s names. Not all systems display such an imbalance, however; this appears to be the case in Trentino (Cesarini Sforza 1895, Rabanus 2023), where personal articles seem to show no sensitivity to the gender of the name.

Despite Oroz’s early characterization, the data suggest that contemporary Chilean Spanish aligns more closely with Trentino than with Venetian. According to Tieperman (2020) and Tieperman & Regan (2023), speakers from Santiago use personal articles with around 79.6% of female-referring names and 63.8% of male-referring ones. While an important bias toward feminine referents is present, a rate of nearly 64% of masculine personal articles indicates that the construction is not gender-restricted at the grammatical level, i.e., the use of personal articles with masculine names is also systematic. The source of the asymmetry must be then tentatively attributed to non-grammatical factors.⁵

Further evidence for this conclusion comes from the fact that contemporary speakers of Chilean Spanish do not perceive any acceptability contrast in minimal pairs such as (18) and (19): the “affectation” originally reported by Oroz (1966) for examples such as (18a) does not seem to distinguish the pattern from examples such as (19a). Since the gender asymmetry does not appear to be related to grammatical well-formedness, it will play no role in the syntactic analysis developed in section 4.

- (18) a. Ayer vimos a Valeria en la piscina.
yesterday saw.1PL DOM Valeria in the pool
‘Yesterday we saw Valeria at the pool.’
b. Ayer vimos a la Valeria en la piscina.
yesterday saw.1PL DOM the Valeria in the pool
‘Yesterday we saw Valeria at the pool.’
- (19) a. Ayer vimos a Jorge en la piscina.
yesterday saw.1PL DOM Jorge in the pool
‘Yesterday we saw Jorge at the pool.’

⁴Garrido-Sepúlveda et al. (2024) interpret this tendency as being shaped by prescriptive traditions of the nineteenth century, in particular by the grammar of Andrés Bello (1847). As noted by Garrido-Sepúlveda et al., Bello explicitly states that “proper names of persons and animate beings, such as *Alejandro*, *César*, *Rocinante*, *Mizifuf*, generally do not admit the definite article” (1847: 199, my translation), but later adds that “I do not believe there is any reason to censure the definite article that is almost always used with women’s proper names in some parts of America: *la Juanita*, *la Isabel*, *la Dolores*” (1847: 200, my translation).

⁵Rabanus (2023) reports a similar asymmetry in South Tyrolean Bavarian dialects: personal articles appear 95.08% of the time with masculine names and 80% with feminine ones. He also hints that the explanation may lie in factors beyond grammar.

- b. Ayer vimos al Jorge en la piscina.
 yesterday saw.1PL DOM.the Jorge in the pool
 ‘Yesterday we saw Jorge at the pool.’

In sum, the frequency asymmetries in the use of personal articles documented across this section are too large to be attributed to stylistic variation alone. The rates reported by Tieperman of 70.2% in Santiago, compared to 10.8% in Granada and 2.6% in Mexico City, do not merely reflect a stronger preference for an expressive option that speakers across varieties share. A construction used in nearly three out of four times is not a marked choice: it is the default. This strongly suggests that in Chilean Spanish the presence of personal articles is governed by systematic grammatical factors rather than by expressive needs, and that the Chilean pattern is therefore qualitatively distinct from what is found in other varieties.

3 Reassessing anaphoric and expressive analyses of personal articles

Personal articles are attested in many Spanish varieties, but only a limited number of explicit analyses have been proposed to account for their distribution and interpretation. In this section, I argue that the two accounts found in the literature, namely that personal articles function as anaphoric markers or that they encode expressive meanings towards the referent of the name, do not adequately capture the Chilean Spanish data. The conclusion that neither analysis fits Chilean Spanish aligns with recent observations by Garrido-Sepúlveda et al. (2024) based on diachronic data.

3.1 Personal articles as anaphoric markers

Unlike Modern Greek, Classical Greek exhibited optionality in the presence of the definite determiner with personal names. As illustrated in (20), personal names could appear either with or without the article in otherwise comparable contexts.

- (20) a. oupou ēn ho Iōannēs baptizōn
 where was the John baptizing
 ‘Where John was baptizing’
 b. kai emarturēsen Iōannēs legōn hoti
 and testified John saying that
 ‘and John testified, saying that...’

Classical Greek (Guardiano 2011: 191)

In the traditional grammatical literature on Classical Greek (e.g., Kühner & Gerth 1870, Gildersleeve 1911, Smyth 1920), the appearance of the article with a proper name is not taken to contribute definiteness, but rather to signal that the referent is already present, activated, or otherwise recoverable in the discourse. Conversely, the absence of the article is associated with contexts in which the referent is newly introduced, weakly anchored, or does not require explicit discourse linking. This view is succinctly summarized by Levinsohn (1991: 91):

Insofar as a consensus among Greek grammarians exists, it is that names of persons normally are not preceded by the article (they are *anarthrous*), but may be preceded by the article (be *arthrous*) if the reference is anaphoric. However, Winer (1882: 140) considers that, in fact, the use of the article with proper names “can hardly be reduced to any rule”.

(Levinsohn 1991: 91)

Under this view, personal articles in Classical Greek function as discourse cohesion markers that allow to link different parts of a text by pointing back to an established referent. On this analysis, the distribution of the article follows from its anaphoric role: its presence distinguishes subsequent mentions of a referent from its initial introduction, which typically lacks overt determination.

Levinsohn (1991: 93) illustrates this pattern with the distribution of articles in references to the proconsul *Gallio* in Acts 18:12, 14, and 17. The relevant verses are reproduced in (21). As can be seen, the first mention of the proper name *Gallio* lacks a determiner, whereas subsequent mentions of the same referent incorporate the personal article. This pattern is consistent with an anaphoric functioning of the personal article and, therefore, supports the traditional view that these elements serve as anaphoric markers.

- (21) **Gallionos** de anthypateuontos tēs Achaïas katepestēsan homothymadon hoi Ioudaioi tō Paulō kai ēgagon auton epi to bēma, legontes hoti para ton nomon houtos anapeithei tous anthrōpous sebesthai ton Theon. Mellontos de tou Paulou anoigein to stoma eipen **ho Galliōn** pros tous Ioudaious: Ei men oun ēn adikēma ti ē rhadiourgēma ponēron, ō Ioudaioi, kata logon an ēnechomēn hymōn; ei de zētēma estin peri logou kai onomatōn kai nomou tou kath’ hymas, opsesthe autoi; kritēs gar egō toutōn ou boulomai einai. Kai apēlasen autous apo tou bēmatos. Epilabomenoi de pantes hoi Hellēnes Sōsthenēn ton archisynagōgon etypton emprosthen tou bēmatos, kai ouden toutōn **tō Galliōni** emelen.

ENG: But while **Gallio** was proconsul of Achaia, the Jews rose up together against Paul and brought him before the judgment seat, saying that this man persuades people to worship God contrary to the law. When Paul was about to open his mouth, **the Gallio** said to the Jews, “If it were some wrongdoing or wicked crime, O Jews, it would be reasonable for me to put up with you; but if it is a dispute about words and names and your own law, see to it yourselves. I do not wish to be a judge of such matters.” And he drove them away from the judgment seat. Then all the Greeks seized Sosthenes, the ruler of the synagogue, and were beating him before the judgment seat, and **the Gallio** paid no attention to any of this.

Calderón Campos (2015) advances a related analysis for personal names with definite articles in Old Spanish. According to his account, however, personal articles do not behave uniformly across text genres. In historical chronicles and witness statements, personal articles are argued to have an anaphoric value and to function as cohesion devices comparable to expressions such as *el dicho* ‘the aforementioned’. In these contexts, the presence of the definite article signals that the referent has already been introduced in the discourse and is retrieved anaphorically. By contrast, in literary texts that imitate spoken language, Calderón Campos argues that personal articles convey a range of expressive meanings. In such cases, the article is associated with nuances of familiarity, closeness, or subjective evaluation, rather than with discourse anaphora. For present purposes, however, the focus will be restricted to those examples that have been taken to support an anaphoric interpretation of personal articles.

The passage in (22), taken from a witness statement dated 1717, is one of the examples discussed by Calderón Campos (2015: 88). As can be seen, the first mentions of the referents *Miguel Barranco* and *Francisco Ruiz* occur without a determiner, while subsequent mentions of these same referents surface with the definite article.⁶

- (22) A la segunda pregunta dijo [...] que [...] viniendo [...] un mozo con un jumento cargado con yerba, le habían venido siguiendo por dicha calle **Miguel Barranco** y **Francisco Ruiz**, portero y ministro de esta dicha ciudad [...] por desirse llevaba una bayoneta. El dicho don Antonio Rodríguez había llegado a dicho alboroto y pedido a dichos ministros soltasen a el referido hombre [...] y que aunque **el Francisco Ruiz** le había obedecido, **el Miguel Barranco** no había querido soltarlo.

ENG: ‘To the second question, he said [...] that [...] coming [...] a young man with a donkey loaded with grass, **Miguel Barranco** and **Francisco Ruiz**, the doorkeeper and minister of this city, had been following him down that street [...] because he was carrying a bayonet. The aforementioned Don Antonio Rodríguez had arrived at this commotion and asked the ministers to release the referred man [...] and that although **the Francisco Ruiz** had obeyed him, **the Miguel Barranco** did not want to let him go.’

A further instance of the same pattern, also taken from Calderón Campos (2015: 88), is offered in (23). This example is likewise drawn from a witness statement and it is dated 1797.

- (23) Por las preguntas siguientes, serán examinados los testigos que se presentasen por parte de Josef, Gaspar y Nicolás Rodríguez [...] en los autos que siguen [...] con **Thomás** y Manuel Tortosa, de la propia vecindad, sobre haber estos supuesto que aquellos maltrataron de obra y de palabra a **el Thomás** y su mujer.

⁶Some of the examples discussed by Calderón Campos (2015) fail to provide unambiguous support for an anaphoric analysis of personal articles. He cites examples from historical chronicles such as those in (i) and (ii), which at first sight glance seem compatible with an anaphoric account, since the determinerless form introduces the referent and the determined form retrieves it. A closer inspection, however, reveals a complication. In both passages, the initial occurrences of *Juan* and *Francisco Martín* are used in a denominative fashion (i.e., *llamado Juan* ‘called Juan’ and *se llamaba Francisco Martín* ‘he was called Francisco Martín’), a type of context in which personal articles are independently disallowed in languages such as Modern Greek and Spanish. As a result, the absence of the article in these cases cannot be straightforwardly attributed to their status as initial discourse mentions.

- (i) envió a uno, llamado **Juan**, a África, contra los sarracenos [...] y habida victoria d’ellos, dexó **el Juan** su ejército en la mejor manera que pudo.

ENG: ‘He sent one, named **Juan**, to Africa, against the Saracens [...] and having obtained victory over them, **the Juan** left his army in the best way he could.’

- (ii) y se abrazaron e besaron muchas veces [...] porque eran muy amigos de antes, y por la novedad del caso y por el remedio deste cristiano, el cual se llamaba **Francisco Martín**, y era uno de los que se perdieron con el capitán Íñigo de Vasuña [...] y llegados al pueblo, no hallaron a nadie en él: que habían los indios huido al arcabuco o monte. Y **el Francisco Martín** los fue a llamar.

ENG: ‘And they embraced and kissed each other many times [...] because they were very good friends from before, and because of the novelty of the situation and the remedy of this Christian, who was named **Francisco Martín**, and was one of those who got lost with Captain Íñigo de Vasuña [...] and when they arrived at the village, they found no one in it: the Indians had fled to the thicket or mountain. And **the Francisco Martín** called them.’

ENG: ‘By the following questions, the witnesses presented on behalf of Josef, Gaspar, and Nicolás Rodríguez will be examined [...] in the proceedings that they are pursuing [...] against **Thomás** and Manuel Tortosa, of the same town, concerning the allegation that the latter claimed the former mistreated **the Thomás** and his wife both physically and verbally.’

Given these examples, one might ask whether personal articles in Chilean Spanish could function in a similar fashion, i.e., as anaphoric markers. Such an analysis could, at least in principle, help account for the high frequency of the pattern in this variety, since anaphoric uses of proper names are generally expected to be more frequent than first mentions.

According to Garrido-Sepúlveda et al. (2024), however, personal articles were anaphoric only in the early stages of Chilean Spanish and ceased to function as such around the nineteenth century. They show that in colonial texts it is indeed possible to find anaphoric patterns of the type discussed by Calderón Campos (2015). For instance, the example in (24), taken from Garrido-Sepúlveda et al. (2024: 138), comes from a letter written in 1545. As can be seen, the first mention of *Francisco Martínez* appears without a determiner, while a subsequent occurrence of the same proper name surfaces with the definite article.

- (24) Yo hice en el Perú conciertos y compañías, á tiempo que tomé esta empresa, con **Francisco Martínez** y Pero Sancho de Hoz, que vuestra merced bien conoce; y Pero Sancho, por no poder cumplir conmigo, se apartó del concierto voluntariamente; y **el Francisco Martínez**, desde que vió los gastos y poco provecho, me rogó deshiciese la compañía [...]

ENG: I made agreements and partnerships in Peru, at the time when I undertook this enterprise, with **Francisco Martínez** and Pero Sancho de Hoz, whom Your Grace knows well; and Pero Sancho, being unable to fulfill his obligations to me, withdrew from the agreement of his own accord; and **the Francisco Martínez**, once he saw the expenses and the little profit involved, asked me to dissolve the partnership [...]

From the nineteenth century onward, this type of anaphoric pattern disappears from the available corpora. In fact, examples are found in which the article appears already on the first mention of a personal name. On the basis of these data, Garrido-Sepúlveda et al. conclude that personal articles in modern Chilean Spanish cannot be analyzed as anaphoric devices.⁷

This conclusion is further supported by the acceptability judgments of contemporary speakers of Chilean Spanish. An anaphoric account of personal articles of the type advanced by Calderón Campos (2015) makes a number of clear empirical predictions that can be tested using standard grammatical methodology. In particular, if personal names introduced by a definite article were inherently anaphoric, they should be incompatible with focus interpretations. By definition, focused constituents introduce new information and therefore cannot be anaphoric.

⁷An anonymous reviewer notes an interesting parallel between this diachronic shift and the distinction between strong and weak definite articles proposed by Schwarz (2009) for German. In Schwarz’s system, strong articles encode anaphoric dependency on a previously introduced discourse referent, while weak articles encode uniqueness relative to a contextually salient situation. The historical contrast discussed above maps onto this distinction in a suggestive way: the personal articles attested in older stages of Spanish pattern with Schwarz’s strong article, while the modern personal article, which introduces no anaphoric dependency and are truth-conditionally equivalent to bare proper names, are closer in spirit to a weak article. Whether this parallel can be made theoretically precise is a question that must be left for future research.

This prediction is not borne out in contemporary Chilean Spanish. To begin with, personal articles freely appear in broad focus contexts in which the entire proposition constitutes new information in response to a general question, e.g., (25).

- (25) A: ¿Qué pasó?
 what happened
 ‘What happened?’
 B: El Carlos llamó a los pacos.
 the Carlos called DOM the cops
 ‘Carlos called the cops.’

The same pattern is observed in contexts involving narrow focus, such as fragment answers. In the reply in (26B), the personal name *Carlos* is the focused constituent that resolves the wh-question, and it may surface with a personal article.

- (26) A: ¿Quién dijo eso?
 who said that
 ‘Who said that?’
 B: El Carlos.
 the Carlos.
 ‘Carlos.’

Even more clearly, proper names with personal articles may function as the pivot of a cleft construction, a syntactic position canonically associated with focus. As shown in (27), a personal name introduced by a definite article may occupy this position without any degradation in acceptability.

- (27) A: ¿Quién compró el auto de la Bea?
 who bought the car of the Bea
 ‘Who bought Bea’s car?’
 B: Fue el Carlos el que compró el auto de la Bea.
 was the Carlos the that bought the car of the Bea
 ‘It was Carlos who bought Bea’s car.’

These facts show that proper names with definite articles in Chilean Spanish are fully compatible with both broad and narrow focus interpretations. This behavior is unexpected under an anaphoric analysis and strongly suggests that personal articles in this variety do not function as anaphoric devices.

Further evidence against an anaphoric analysis comes from the fact that Chilean Spanish speakers also accept what may be described as an “inverted pattern”, in which a proper name introduced by a personal article precedes a subsequent bare occurrence of the same name. In (28), the first mention of the proper name *Gonzalo* appears with a personal article, while the second mention surfaces without it. This distribution runs counter to the expectations of an anaphoric account, under which the article is predicted to mark subsequent mentions rather than initial ones. Nevertheless, Chilean Spanish speakers judge the utterance to be fully natural.

- (28) ¿Y por qué no llamamos **al Gonzalo**? Erika siempre dice que **Gonzalo** sabe arreglar computadores.

ENG: ‘Why don’t we call **the Gonzalo**? Erika always says that **Gonzalo** knows how to fix computers.’

A similar pattern is shown in (29), where the initial mention of *Gonzalo* is determined, while two subsequent mentions appear without the personal article. Once again, the alternation between determined and bare forms does not correlate with new versus given status, nor does the omission of the article in later mentions give rise to any interpretive contrast.

- (29) Abrí la puerta y el único que estaba ahí era **el Gonzalo**. Me puse a hablar con él y le dije que teníamos que guardar todo al tiro. El problema fue que **Gonzalo** es más lento que la chucha para hacer cualquier weá; por eso te dije que no me gusta que me asignen a **Gonzalo** en mi grupo.

ENG: ‘I opened the door, and the only one there was **the Gonzalo**. I talked to him and told him that we needed to put everything away right away. The problem was that **Gonzalo** is slow as hell at doing anything; that’s why I told you I don’t like being assigned to a group with **Gonzalo**.’

Additional evidence against an anaphoric analysis comes from naturally occurring spoken data. In particular, Mella Barahona (2012) reports transcripts of an interview with a Chilean married couple, Silvia and Juan, in which Silvia alternates between determined and bare uses of her husband’s name within a short stretch of discourse. Crucially, occurrences of the personal name with the definite article precede subsequent bare occurrences, a pattern that is incompatible with an anaphoric account. The examples in (30), reproduced in the order in which they appear in the transcript (Annex 9 in Mella Barahona 2012), illustrate this alternation. As can be seen, the mentions of *Juan* in (30a) appear with a personal article, while later mentions surface without it, despite referring to the same individual.

- (30) a. y fui yo con el Juan y le dije al Juan...
and went.1SG I with the Juan and 3SG.DAT said.3SG DOM.the Juan
‘and I went with Juan and I told him...’
b. entonces le dije a Juan...
then 3SG.DAT said.3SG DOM Juan
‘Then I told Juan...’
c. yo siempre le decía a Juan...
I always 3SG.DAT said.3SG DOM Juan
‘I always used to tell Juan...’

Taken together, these facts are incompatible with an analysis that treats personal articles in (contemporary) Chilean Spanish as anaphoric devices. The availability of determined personal names in first-mention contexts, their compatibility with focus, and the existence of inverted patterns in which bare forms follow determined ones all indicate that definite articles with proper names in Chilean Spanish do not encode discourse anaphora.

3.2 Personal articles as expressivity markers

Let us now consider the possibility that personal articles in Chilean Spanish convey some form of expressivity. As already discussed, definite articles preceding human-denoting proper names are standardly taken to encode speaker-oriented meanings in many Spanish varieties. The question, then, is whether this characterization can be extended to Chilean Spanish.

Before addressing this question, however, a terminological clarification is in order. As discussed in Gutzmann (2013), the notion of *expressivity* is used in at least two senses. In a broad sense, it refers to any dimension of meaning that is not truth-conditional but use-conditional, i.e., meaning that imposes conditions on the felicitous use of an utterance. This encompasses a wide range of phenomena such as parentheticals, forms of address, discourse particles, and conventionalized forms associated with stylistic markedness and register; this approach has been developed most systematically within multidimensional approaches to meaning (e.g., Potts 2005, McCready 2010, 2019, Gutzmann 2013, 2015, and Saab (2026) specifically for Spanish). In a narrower sense, the term *expressivity* refers specifically to use-conditional content conveying the speaker's affective or evaluative attitude toward the argument of an expression. This is the most prototypical use of the term, and it is usually applied to characterize phenomena such as epithets, interjections, and slurs. It is this narrower sense that has been operative in the literature on Spanish personal articles, as these elements have been claimed to convey familiarity, affection, pejoration, disrespect, or annoyance toward the referent of the name.

Personal articles are expressive elements in the broad sense. As discussed earlier, in most varieties they are characteristic of rural speech, very colloquial registers, or slang, and their use is generally regarded as substandard; this amounts to describe them as forms introducing register-related use-conditions. Since they do not affect the truth-value of the sentences they appear in, personal articles must be regarded as expressive elements in the more general interpretation of the term.

The situation for Chilean Spanish is similar in this regard, although with some nuances. As already pointed out, personal articles in this variety are, in Oroz's (1966: 371, my translation) words, "not limited to rustic or vulgar speech, but can be considered almost a general norm," a characterization explicitly endorsed by normative institutions (see Figure 1). While the distribution of personal articles in Chilean Spanish is considerably wider than in other varieties, it is not entirely free of register-related restrictions. Native speakers judge their use as out of place in highly formal contexts, professional written texts and institutional settings. The examples in (31) to (33) illustrate this trend.⁸

(31) [*The speaker is a witness in a trial*]

Vi que (#el) Rodrigo salió del edificio a las nueve de la noche.
saw.1sg that the Rodrigo went.out.3sg of.the building at the nine of the night

'I saw Rodrigo coming out of the building at nine at night.'

(32) [*The speaker is defending their thesis before the evaluation committee*]

Como propone (#la) Herrera en su estudio del 2024...
as proposes.3sg the Herrera in her study of.the 2024

'As Herrera proposes in her 2024 study...'

⁸The acceptability judgments in (31) to (36) were not collected from students but were reported to me by Magdalena Covarrubias (p.c.).

- (33) [*Fragment of a written police report*]

El día 15 de marzo, (#el) Andrés Valenzuela fue visto en las cercanías del
the day 15 of March the Andrés Valenzuela was.3SG seen in the surroundings of.the
domicilio.
residence

‘On March 15th, Andrés Valenzuela was seen near the residence.’

At the same time, personal articles in Chilean Spanish may surface in contexts of intermediate formality where they would be unacceptable in other varieties. The examples in (34) and (35) illustrate this.

- (34) [*A doctor speaks with a colleague during a medical consultation*]

(El) Diego Soto presentó mejoría después del tratamiento.
the Diego Soto showed.3SG improvement after of.the treatment

‘Diego Soto showed improvement after treatment.’

- (35) [*The speaker is giving a speech at a fancy wedding*]

Conocí a(l) Carlos en la universidad y desde entonces somos inseparables.
met.1SG DOM.the Carlos in the university and since then are.1PL inseparable

‘I met Carlos at university and since then we have been inseparable.’

Similarly, the acceptability of an utterance with personal articles could vary depending on its intended recipient. Assume the sentence in (36) appears in an email written by a member of a company’s sales team. If the email is directed to a client, the use of the personal article sounds inappropriate, as it conveys a degree of informality that renders it unprofessional; however, if circulated internally among members of the same team, the use of the personal article remains natural.

- (36) En adelante, la Javiera Campos se encargará de estos productos.
in ahead the Javiera Campos REFL take.charge.3SG of these products
‘From now on, Javiera Campos will be in charge of these products.’

Taken together, these examples show that personal articles in Chilean Spanish are use-conditional, and therefore expressive in the broad sense of Gutzmann (2013): their distribution is sensitive to register. The question that remains, then, is whether they are also expressive in the narrower sense, i.e., whether they convey speaker-oriented attitudes toward the referent of the proper name. This question can be addressed using the diagnostics developed by Oggiani & Aguilar Guevara (2024), whose analysis I take as a starting point.

Oggiani & Aguilar Guevara (2024) provide an empirically testable characterization of the semantic contribution of personal articles in Spanish. As they observe, previous discussion on the semantic import of Spanish personal articles typically revolves around the notion of *familiarity* (e.g., Saab 2021, Espinal To Appear, Cornilescu 2025). The problem with analyzing personal articles in terms of familiarity, they argue, is that bare proper names already presuppose it. For instance, the reply in (37B) is infelicitous if the referent of the bare proper name *Julia* is not familiar to speaker A. If the semantic contribution of personal articles was indeed familiarity, then determined and determinerless forms of a proper name should be fully synonymous, contrary to what is usually reported.

- (37) A: What did you do yesterday?
 B: # Yesterday I met Julia.

Instead, Oggiani & Aguilar Guevara (2024) propose that the contribution of the personal article in Spanish should be analyzed in terms of *interpersonal proximity*, which they define as the speaker's sense of closeness with the referent of the personal name; the relevant bond can be either positive or negative, and thus it may reflect admiration or affection toward the referent just as well as pejoration or disrespect. Interpersonal proximity is a unidirectional type of relation, in the sense that only the speaker's attitude is relevant, independently of whether the referent reciprocates or is even aware of the relationship. This aspect of the analysis captures the observation by Saab (2021) that personal articles are often used with the names of well known or famous individuals.

To illustrate the interpretation associated with interpersonal proximity, Oggiani & Aguilar Guevara draw on examples from substandard Rioplatense Spanish. The pair in (38) illustrates the basic contrast. As can be seen, the bare proper name in (38a) receives a purely referential interpretation, whereas the determined form in (38b) conveys that the speaker feels a close bond with the referent of the proper name.

- (38) a. María vino a mi fiesta.
 María came to my party.
 'María came to my party.'
- b. La María vino a mi fiesta.
 the María came to my party.
 'María came to my party + I feel close to her.'
- substandard Rioplatense Spanish (Oggiani & Aguilar Guevara 2024: 318)*

Oggiani & Aguilar Guevara further argue that this interpretation is not merely optional or contextually inferred, but conventionally associated with nominal expressions that combine a definite article and a proper name. In particular, they contend that personal articles impose specific use conditions: an utterance containing a personal article is felicitous only if the speaker feels a close bond with the referent of the proper name, or intends to convey such a bond. This characterization leads to a clear empirical prediction: personal articles should be infelicitous in contexts in which the referent is presented as someone the speaker is not well acquainted with.

This prediction is borne out in the examples in (39). In these contexts, the speaker introduces the referent as a newly encountered individual, such as a new roommate, a recent date, or a new boss. While the bare proper name in (39a) is fully acceptable, the use of a personal article in (39b) is degraded, since it would incorrectly signal a close interpersonal bond that the discourse context explicitly denies.

- (39) [Carla is the speaker's new roommate / Tinder date / boss]
- a. Hoy conocí a Carla.
 today met DOM Carla
 'Today I met Carla.'
- b. #Hoy conocí a la Carla
 today met DOM the Carla
 'Today I met Carla.'
- substandard Rioplatense Spanish (Aguilar-Guevara & Oggiani 2023)*

A similar effect is observed when the referent of the proper name is explicitly described as someone the speaker has never met. In (40a), the bare proper name *Julia* is acceptable in a sentence that introduces the referent as a relative whom the speaker has never encountered. By contrast, the determined form in (40b) is degraded, since the personal article signals a close interpersonal bond that is explicitly contradicted by the relative clause *que nunca vimos* ‘that we never saw’.

- (40) a. Hoy viene a mi casa Julia, una prima de mi padre que nunca vimos.
 today comes to my house Julia a cousin of my father that never saw
 ‘Today Julia is coming to my place, a cousin of my father whom we have never met.’
 b. #Hoy viene a mi casa la Julia, una prima de mi padre que nunca vimos.
 today comes to my house the Julia, a cousin of my father that never saw
 ‘Today Julia is coming to my place, a cousin of my father whom we have never met.’
substandard Rioplatense Spanish (Aguilar-Guevara & Oggiani 2023)

The same incompatibility arises in utterances that explicitly deny knowledge of the referent. In the exchange in (41), speaker A uses a personal article when mentioning someone named *Carlos*. Speaker B can respond felicitously using the bare proper name, as in (41B), thereby indicating they do not know the person. By contrast, the use of the personal article in (41B’) is degraded, since it would signal interpersonal proximity while simultaneously denying any acquaintance. The determined form may be taken to be acceptable only under a metalinguistic or echoic interpretation, as illustrated in (41B’”), in which the speaker treats the determiner proper name itself as an object of reference rather than as a referential expression.

- (41) A: Fui a la casa del Carlos y no me abrió la puerta. ¿Podés creerlo?
 went to the house of.the Carlos and not me open the door. Can believe.it
 ‘I went to Carlos’s house and he didn’t open the door. Can you believe it?’
 B: Es que no sé quién es Carlos.
 is that not know who is Carlos
 ‘I don’t know who Carlos is.’
 B’: #Es que no sé quién es el Carlos.
 is that not know who is the Carlos
 ‘I don’t know who Carlos is.’
 B’’: Es que no sé quién es “el Carlos”.
 is that not know who is the Carlos
 ‘I don’t know who “Carlos” is.’
substandard Rioplatense Spanish (Aguilar-Guevara & Oggiani 2023)

Taken together, these contrasts show that personal articles in substandard Rioplatense Spanish are expressive elements in the narrow sense: their felicity is conditioned on the speaker’s attitude toward the referent of the proper name; specifically, on whether the speaker is able to convey interpersonal proximity with that individual. These patterns thus provide a clear diagnostic for referent-oriented expressivity, and will serve as a point of comparison in the evaluation of Chilean Spanish data.

Chilean Spanish speakers are largely insensitive to the distinctions that give rise to infelicity in substandard Rioplatense Spanish. In contexts that explicitly deny acquaintance with the referent of the

personal name, personal articles remain fully acceptable. The examples in (42), (43) and (44) illustrate this point.

- (42) Jamás conoceré al Matías Contreras.
 never will.meet DOM.the Matías Contreras
 'I will never meet Matías Contreras.'
- (43) Mañana viene a mi casa la Patricia, una prima de mi papá que ni sabíamos
 tomorrow comes to my house the Patricia, a cousin of my dad that not.even we.knew
 que existía.
 that existed
 'Tomorrow Patricia, a cousin of my dad whom we did not even know existed, is coming to my house.'
- (44) A: Oye, ¿sabíh que fui a la casa del Diego Soto y no me quiso abrir la
 listen know that went to the house of.the Diego Soto and not me wanted open the
 puerta?
 door
 'Listen, can you believe that I went to Diego Soto's place and he didn't open the door?'
 B: ¿Y quién es el Diego Soto?
 and who is the Diego Soto
 'And who is Diego Soto?'

Unlike in Rioplatense Spanish, the presence of a personal article in Chilean Spanish is not degraded when the referent is presented as unknown, newly encountered, or as someone the speaker will never meet. The personal article in Chilean Spanish cannot therefore be taken to convey interpersonal proximity. Since this is precisely the notion that subsumes the referent-oriented expressive meanings associated with personal articles across Spanish varieties, its absence in Chilean Spanish leads to a clear conclusion: personal articles in this variety are not expressive in the narrow sense.

Further evidence in the same direction comes from contexts in which the speaker themselves is the referent of the proper name. If personal articles encoded interpersonal proximity, their use in self-referential contexts would be unexpected, since the notion of closeness toward oneself is pragmatically odd. Nevertheless, Chilean Spanish speakers readily accept determined personal names in such contexts, as shown in (45) and (46).

- (45) [A new teacher is taking attendance.]
 A: ¿Quiénes son Pedro y José?
 who are Pedro and José
 'Who are Pedro and José?'
 B: ¡Yo soy (el) José!
 I am the José
 'I am José!'
- (46) [Ding dong]
 A: ¿Quién es?
 who is
 'Who is it?'

- B: Soy (el) Carlos.
am the Carlos.
'I am Carlos.'

Additional support for this conclusion comes from informal elicitation with native speakers of Chilean Spanish. When presented with a minimal pair such as (47), informants consistently report no discernible interpretive difference between the two forms: no sense of admiration, affection, pejoration, or disrespect toward the referent could be detected.

- (47) a. Vino Carlos.
came Carlos
'Carlos came.'
b. Vino el Carlos.
came the Carlos
'Carlos came.'

When prompted to comment on potential contrasts between these variants, informants offered a range of tentative interpretations. One speaker suggested that the bare form might make it harder to identify the intended referent (e.g., that it could refer to “any Carlos”), although this intuition was strongly rejected by all other informants. Others characterized the determinerless variant as “less redundant”, or described it as more neutral and, in a loose sense, less characteristic of Chilean Spanish. Importantly, these last contrasts are expressive in the broad sense: they pertain to register and style rather than to any evaluative attitude toward the referent of the name. None of the impressions reported correspond to the kinds of referent-oriented expressive meanings that personal articles encode in other Spanish varieties.

Converging evidence that personal articles in Chilean Spanish do not function as expressive markers (in the narrow sense) comes from the quantitative study by Garrido-Sepúlveda et al. (2024). The authors analyze a corpus of 169 literary instances of personal articles spanning the nineteenth to the twenty-first centuries to assess whether the use of the article correlates with evaluative meanings. To this end, each example was manually annotated according to whether it could be plausibly associated with a positive evaluation of the referent, a negative evaluation, or no discernible expressive content at all; the decision was based on factors such as narrative stance and the presence of speech acts like praise, mockery, or offense.

The results show that expressive interpretations are clearly not predominant. The majority of occurrences, approximately 72%, appear in pragmatically unmarked contexts and cannot be associated with any identifiable evaluative content. A smaller subset of cases, around 19.5%, is compatible with a positive stance toward the referent, while only about 8% can be plausibly linked to a negative evaluation. This distribution leads the authors to conclude, in line with the argument developed here, that expressive meaning (in the narrow sense) is not a defining property of personal articles in Chilean Spanish.

In sum, the diagnostics that successfully identify personal articles as expressive markers in varieties such as substandard Rioplatense Spanish fail to extend to Chilean Spanish. Personal articles in this variety remain acceptable in contexts that are incompatible with interpersonal proximity, and quantitative evidence confirms that evaluative interpretations are not characteristic of the pattern. These results

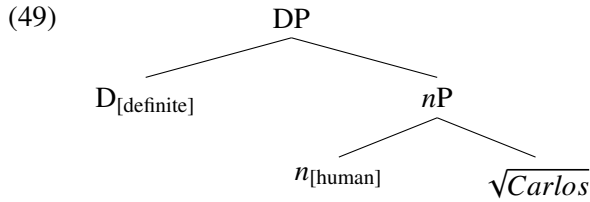
converge on a single conclusion: personal articles in Chilean Spanish do not encode referent-oriented expressive meaning and, therefore, differ fundamentally from their counterparts in other Spanish varieties.

4 The grammar of personal articles in Chilean Spanish

Having established that personal articles in Chilean Spanish are neither anaphoric elements nor markers of interpersonal proximity, we can now turn to the analysis advanced in this paper. There are two core properties that need to be accounted for: (i) why the personal article is optional in Chilean Spanish, and (ii) why its presence introduces no meaning difference relative to a bare personal name (beyond the register-related use conditions discussed above). The pair in (48) illustrates both properties.

- (48) a. [DP Carlos] llegó temprano.
 Carlos arrived.3sg early
 ‘Carlos arrived early.’
 b. [DP El Carlos] llegó temprano.
 the Carlos arrived.3sg early
 ‘Carlos arrived early.’

As a general framework, I follow Saab & Lo Guercio (2020) in assuming that referential and predicative uses of personal names involve different underlying syntactic representations; since predicative uses fall outside the scope of the discussion, I focus exclusively on the syntax of referential uses. Saab & Lo Guercio propose that these have a minimal structure consisting of three elements: a Root, a categorizing little *n* head bearing a [human] feature, and a definite D head; there is no Number projection in the configuration.



On this analysis, the meaning of a personal name obtains at the *nP* level by combining an *n* head and a name Root, e.g., $\sqrt{\text{Carlos}}$. By allosemy, this minimal [*n* $\sqrt{\text{ }}$] complex is interpreted at LF as an entity-denoting object of type $\langle e \rangle$.

$$(50) \quad [{}_{nP} n \sqrt{\text{Carlos}}] \leftrightarrow \llbracket \text{Carlos} \rrbracket / D \text{ ___}$$

The D head selecting this *nP* makes no independent semantic contribution: it receives an allosemantic realization as an identity function. In this sense, Saab & Lo Guercio’s proposal amounts to treating D in proper names as a semantically vacuous element with a purely structural role.

$$(51) \quad D_{[\text{definite}]} \leftrightarrow \lambda x.x / \text{ ___ } [{}_{nP} n \sqrt{\text{ ___ }}]$$

I take the representation in (49) to be an abstraction over the DPs in (48a) and (48b) that encodes what they share at the syntactic level. Their surface differences follow from further operations that apply to this common base.

4.1 A first fork: syntax or PF

The proposal follows the spirit of Longobardi (1994), who characterizes personal articles as expletive-like elements in the sense that they do not contribute any semantic content beyond what is already encoded in the bare proper name. On this view, the co-occurrence of a definite article with a personal name must follow from a grammatical requirement rather than from a semantic or pragmatic choice. Thus, the optionality of the alternation in (48) implies that Chilean Spanish speakers must have access to two alternative sets of grammatical rules for personal names: (i) a conservative set, which aligns with the pan-Hispanic norm in which personal names surface without a determiner, and (ii) an innovative, locally stabilized, and preferred one, which systematically introduces an overt definite article. When a speaker draws on the conservative rule set, they produce forms such as *Carlos*, *Josefina*, or *Mariel*; when they draw on the innovative one, the corresponding outputs are *el Carlos*, *la Josefina*, or *la Mariel*. The immediate question is where in the grammar these competing sets of rules are encoded. In principle, there are two options: either they are narrow-syntactic in nature, or they apply at PF, i.e., they involve post-syntactic mechanisms.

A classical implementation of the syntactic option is the N-to-D analysis advanced by Longobardi (1994). In Longobardi's system, both DP structures in (48) satisfy the requirement that the D slot must be filled at the surface level, but they do so through two alternative mechanisms: in the bare form, i.e., *Carlos* in (48a), the proper name moves from N to D and fills the position, while in the personal article case, i.e., *el Carlos* in (48b), the proper name remains in situ and the D position is filled by a phonetically overt but semantically vacuous expletive article.

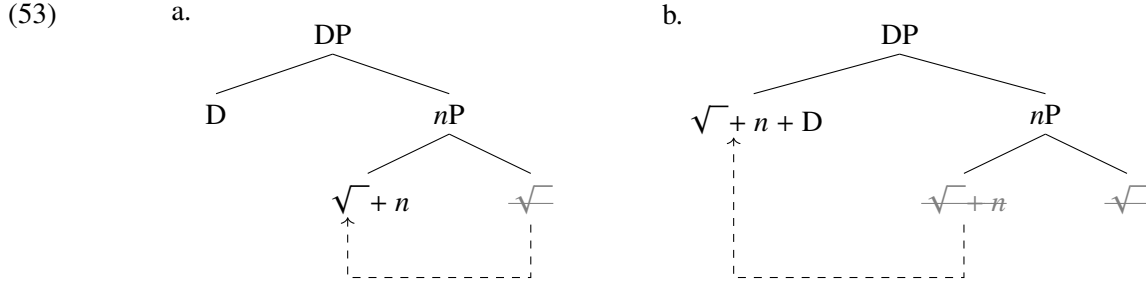
Evidence for this line of analysis comes from Italian. Consider Longobardi's (1994: 623) classic paradigm in (52). In Italian, possessive adjectives may appear either before or after a noun when an article is present, e.g., (52a) vs. (52b). However, if the article is omitted, only the name-first order remains grammatical, e.g., (52c) vs. (52d).⁹ Longobardi's explanation is that without an article to fill the D position, the proper name must undergo movement to D. As it does, it passes over the possessive adjective, so the resulting surface order must end up being N > A rather than A > N.

- (52) a. Il mio Gianni ha finalmente telefonato.
 the my Gianni has.3sg finally called.up
 'My Gianni finally called.'
- b. Il Gianni mio ha finalmente telefonato.
 the Gianni my has.3sg finally called.up
 'My Gianni finally called.'
- c. Gianni mio ha finalmente telefonato.
 Gianni my has.3sg finally called.up
 'My Gianni finally called.'
- d. *Mio Gianni ha finalmente telefonato.
 my Gianni has.3sg finally called.up

⁹The pattern in (52c) is attested in central and southern Italian varieties.

‘My Gianni finally called.’

Longobardi’s account could be straightforwardly incorporated into Saab & Lo Guercio’s (2020) structure in (49). Thus, the conservative derivation for personal names may involve a two-step process: the root first head-moves to *n*, as in (53a), and the resulting complex head then moves to D, as in (53b). In this scenario, the proper name is pronounced in the D position, while the determiner remains phonologically null.



The innovative derivation for personal names in Chilean Spanish might simply skip the movement step in (53b), i.e., the structure of personal names in this case corresponds to (53a). Since the proper name remains within the *nP*, the D head receives an independent phonological exponent and surfaces as an overt definite article.¹⁰

Notice, however, that the absence of any semantic difference between (48a) and (48b) suggests that the syntactic option should be set aside in favor of a post-syntactic account. If the two surface forms shared

¹⁰Following Saab & Lo Guercio (2020), Saab (2025a,b) provides an intriguing argument against an analysis of personal articles in which these are simply the realization of D. His argument is based on the observation that the feminine definite article *la* has an allomorph *el* that appears in the context of nouns starting with an accented /a/.

- (i) *el águila, el agua, el arma*
the eagle, the water, the weapon
‘the eagle, the water, the weapon’

This is typically captured by a vocabulary insertion rule such as (ii).

- (ii) $D_{[\text{definite, feminine, singular}]} \leftrightarrow /el/ \text{ } _ \text{ } [N \text{ } /á.../]$

However, personal articles do not follow this rule: in the context of a feminine proper name that starts with an accented /a/, the determiner *la* appears.

- (iii) *la Ana, la Ángela, la Ágata*

According to Saab, this suggests that personal articles are not true determiners. He proposes that they are dissociated agreement markers introduced in the phonological representation.

While Saab’s point is well taken, the patterns in (iii) may also be interpreted differently: rather than showing that personal articles are not true determiners, these examples may be taken to show that the rule in (ii) is simply too broad: as it stands, it predicts that the allomorphic alternation is triggered by all nouns that begin with an accented /a/, yet proper names are clearly exempt. Perhaps the rule needs to be stated in terms of common nouns, or in terms of some property of common nouns that is not shared with proper names. Further research is needed to determine whether this conjecture is on the right track. For the moment, I will continue to assume that the personal articles *la* and *el* are indeed realizations of D.

tionality of the personal article could be attributed to the presence or absence of an uninterpretable feature [F] on D. If D is bundled with [F], the conservative derivation obtains: D attracts the proper name, which surfaces in D and leaves the determiner phonologically null, *cf.* (53b). If D lacks [F], the innovative derivation obtains instead: the proper name remains within the *nP* and D receives an independent phonological realization, *cf.* (53a).

Single-grammar accounts are also available under a PF treatment of the alternation.¹³ Assume, for example, that the syntactic structure sent to PF, i.e., (49), corresponds to a masculine personal name. In this scenario, both vocabulary insertion rules in (54a) and (55a) are available in the speaker's grammar, so both the bare and the determined forms of the personal name are derivable. The competition between them could then be resolved by, in the words of Embick (2008), a "coin-toss" at PF, with selection of the relevant rule being probabilistic rather than deterministic.

While the single-grammar analyses sketched above are compatible with the alternation in (48), I will argue that the full distribution of personal articles in Chilean Spanish calls for a more structured account. Following Roeper (1999) and Amaral & Roeper (2014), I assume that a speaker's grammatical system may contain multiple *subgrammars*: distinct, internally consistent sets of rules that coexist within a single grammar. I therefore propose that Chilean Spanish speakers have at least two subgrammars: a conservative pan-Hispanic one, in which personal names appear without a definite article, and an innovative one, in which they co-occur with the personal article. Thus, the optionality of the personal article in Chilean Spanish follows from its speakers being, in a loose sense, "diglossic". Crucially, the two subgrammars are not equally weighted: as the frequency facts reviewed in section 2.2 indicate, the innovative subgrammar functions as the default for Chilean Spanish speakers, with the conservative subgrammar surfacing much less frequently. Note, however, that the innovative subgrammar's default status is register-restricted: it is not deployed in very formal contexts, where speakers resort to the conservative pan-Hispanic subgrammar instead, *cf.* examples (31) to (36).

Evidence supporting a two-subgrammars approach comes from comparing the syntactic behavior of *nominal placeholders* in Rioplatense and Chilean Spanish. A placeholder is a dummy element that occupies a syntactic position corresponding to a target expression that the speaker is unable or unwilling to produce (Podlesskaya 2010, Vogel 2020, Seraku 2022). Such elements are well attested crosslinguistically; English, French, and German, for instance, all employ dedicated nominal placeholders that can stand in for common nouns.

¹³ As observed in footnote 11, the vocabulary insertion rule in (54) does not need to refer to the gender of the article. Thus, the following three rules could be available for the speaker within a single grammar.

- (i) $D_{[\text{definite}]} \leftrightarrow \emptyset / __ [nP \ n \ \sqrt{\ \ }]$
- (ii) $D_{[\text{definite, masculine}]} \leftrightarrow /el/ / __ [nP \ n \ \sqrt{\ \ }]$
- (iii) $D_{[\text{definite, feminine}]} \leftrightarrow /la/ / __ [nP \ n \ \sqrt{\ \ }]$

These rules do not compete with each other, as they apply to terminals with different grammatical feature specifications; since the rules themselves do not compete, the source of the alternation must lie in what determines the featural content of D in the first place. For instance, one could propose that if D does not agree with the proper name and consequently lacks gender features, the rule in (i) applies and the proper name surfaces without a determiner; if D agrees with the proper name, the rules in (ii) or (iii) apply and the personal article surfaces. Alternatively, a PF mechanism such as *impoverishment* may determine whether D bears gender features. There is no shortage of alternative analyses of why the article receives pronunciation; further research into the nominal syntax of Chilean Spanish is necessary to conclusively adjudicate between these options.

- (56) Could you hand me the *whatchamacallit*? English
- (57) Je dois aller chercher mon *machin* chez le réparateur.
 I must go pick my *machin* at the repairman
 ‘I have to go pick up my thingy from the repair shop.’ French
- (58) Ich habe gestern mein *Dingsbums* im Büro vergessen.
 I have yesterday my *Dingsbums* in office forgotten
 ‘I forgot my thingy in the office yesterday.’ German

As discussed by Muñoz Pérez (2026), both Rioplatense and Chilean Spanish display nominal placeholders that can replace nouns in exactly the same way. In Rioplatense Spanish, this function is fulfilled by *coso*, e.g., (59), while in Chilean Spanish the same role is fulfilled by *este*, e.g., (60).

- (59) a. Me falta un *coso*.
 1SG.DAT miss.3SG a *coso*
 ‘I’m missing a thingy.’
 b. No encuentro el *coso*.
 not find.1SG the *coso*
 ‘I can’t find the thingy.’
- (60) a. Me falta un *este*.
 1SG.DAT miss.3SG a *este*
 ‘I’m missing a thingy.’
 b. No encuentro el *este*.
 not find.1SG the *este*
 ‘I can’t find the thingy.’

In both varieties, these placeholders may replace common nouns and personal names, although their syntactic behavior differs in the latter case. In Rioplatense Spanish, when *coso* replaces a personal name, it patterns syntactically with personal names: it rejects the presence of determiners, e.g., (61) vs. (62), and triggers differential object marking (DOM), e.g., (63) vs. (64).¹⁴

- (61) a. Juan dijo eso.
 Juan said.3SG that
 ‘Juan said that.’
 b. *Coso* dijo eso.
coso said.3SG that
 ‘Whatchamacallit said that.’
- (62) a. *El Juan dijo eso.
 the Juan said.3SG that
 ‘Juan said that.’

¹⁴The acceptability of the example in (62a) is for standard Rioplatense Spanish. As discussed in section 3.2, personal articles are attested in substandard Rioplatense Spanish, but only in expressive uses. The examples here involve no expressive intent.

- b. * El Coso dijo eso.
the coso said.3sg that
'Whatchamacallit said that.'
- (63) a. Ayer vi a Juan.
yesterday saw DOM Juan
'I saw Juan yesterday.'
- b. Ayer vi a Coso.
yesterday saw DOM coso
'I saw Whatchamacallit yesterday.'
- (64) a. * Ayer vi Juan.
yesterday saw Juan
'I saw Juan yesterday.'
- b. * Ayer vi Coso.
yesterday saw coso
'I saw Whatchamacallit yesterday.'

By contrast, when Chilean *este* replaces a human-denoting proper name, it does not manifest the optionality attested in pairs such as *Carlos* vs. *el Carlos* in (48): when standing in for a personal name, *este* always requires a definite article. Bare uses of *este* in such contexts are categorically rejected as nominal placeholders. Since the form *este* also corresponds to a demonstrative in Spanish, uses without a determiner can only be interpreted deictically, e.g., (65b) is acceptable if *este* is interpreted as *this one*.

- (65) a. Juan dijo eso.
Juan said.3sg that
'Juan said that.'
- b. * Este dijo eso.
ESTE said.3sg that
'Whatchamacallit said that.'
- (66) a. El Juan dijo eso.
the Juan said.3sg that
'Juan said that.'
- b. El Este dijo eso.
the ESTE said.3sg that
'Whatchamacallit said that.'

That the placeholder *este* patterns with personal names when it stands for them is further corroborated by the behavior of differential object marking. The examples in (67) show that *este* exhibits DOM when used as a personal name, just as proper names do. Conversely, the examples in (68) are ungrammatical under the personal name placeholder reading due to the absence of DOM. Note, however, that (68b) remains acceptable when *el este* receives a non-human inanimate reading, in which it literally means *the thingy*.

- (67) a. Ayer vi al Juan.
yesterday saw DOM.the Juan

- ‘I saw Juan yesterday.’
- b. Ayer vi al Este.
yesterday saw DOM.the ESTE
‘I saw Whatchamacallit yesterday.’
- (68) a. *Ayer vi el Juan.
yesterday saw the Juan
‘I saw Juan yesterday.’
- b. *Ayer vi el Este.
yesterday saw the ESTE
‘I saw Whatchamacallit yesterday.’

The behavior of *este* seems incompatible with a single-grammar account of personal articles in Chilean Spanish. Such an account does not capture that personal articles and the placeholder *este* form a cluster: when *este* is used as a personal name placeholder in Chilean Spanish, it invariably surfaces with the definite article, never without it. Under a unified grammatical system, this clustering is entirely unexpected. If all the rules governing the derivation of bare personal names, the introduction of personal articles, and the use of *este* as a placeholder belonged to a single system, as schematically represented in (69), then all such rules would be equally accessible. Nothing would then prevent *este* from being derived by either the rules for bare personal names or those for personal articles, and the placeholder should therefore display the same optionality as real personal names, appearing freely with or without the definite article. This prediction is not borne out: as established by (65b), bare *este* is categorically rejected as a placeholder for a personal name.

- (69) “UNDIVIDED” CHILEAN SPANISH GRAMMAR
- a. Rules for bare personal names
 - b. Rules for personal articles
 - c. Rules for the placeholder *este*
 - d. Other rules

The restriction follows straightforwardly if Chilean Spanish speakers have two subgrammars organized as in (70). I contend that the rules governing the use of the placeholder *este* are part of the innovative Chilean subgrammar, a claim supported by the fact that this element is ungrammatical (with this function) in other Spanish varieties. Since the only rules for personal names within the innovative subgrammar involve personal articles, *este* must rely on those rules when standing in for a personal name; in a sense, the placeholder *este* is parasitic on the personal article when functioning as a personal name. Conversely, since the conservative subgrammar contains no rules for *este*, the use of the placeholder without a definite article is ruled-out.¹⁵

¹⁵A secondary prediction stemming from this analysis is that Chilean Spanish speakers might be able to produce utterances in which the personal article is intended to convey interpersonal proximity. While the innovative subgrammar (70b) is the preferred option by these speakers, it is conceivable that, when they use the more conservative and Pan-Hispanic subgrammar in (70a), they could produce personal articles with interpretations similar to those in other Spanish varieties. One potential way to model this is by positing that the conservative subgrammar, just as many other Spanish varieties, contains rules to produce a syntactic representation such as (71) below, which is according to Oggiani & Aguilar Guevara (2024) responsible for the interpersonal proximity reading of personal articles.

(70) “DIGLOSSIC” CHILEAN SPANISH GRAMMAR

- a. Conservative pan-Hispanic subgrammar
 - i. Rules for bare personal names
 - ii. Other rules
- b. Innovative Chilean subgrammar
 - i. Rules for personal articles
 - ii. Rules for the placeholder *este*
 - iii. Other rules

In sum, the systematic presence of the definite article with the placeholder *este* provides evidence that the conservative and innovative subgrammars are genuinely distinct components of the grammatical competence of Chilean Spanish speakers. This two-subgrammar architecture has a direct consequence for how the optionality of personal articles in Chilean Spanish should be understood. The alternation between bare personal names and personal names with a definite article does not reflect, on this approach, a choice between two semantically or pragmatically distinct options within a single grammatical system. Rather, it reflects the selection of one subgrammar over the other; in other words, the choice stems from (sub)grammar competition.

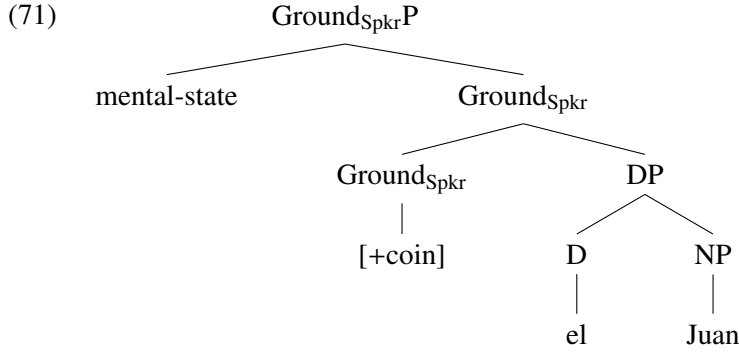
As a final note, it is worth emphasizing that the subgrammar divide argued for here is orthogonal to the question raised in subsection 4.1 of whether the personal article alternation is located in the narrow syntax or at PF. That question concerns the derivational mechanism by which individual forms are generated. The present proposal concerns the higher-level organization of the speaker’s grammatical knowledge into distinct subsystems. Both a syntactic and a PF implementation of the personal article alternation are therefore compatible with the two-subgrammar architecture advanced here.

4.3 Notes for the comparative analysis of personal articles in Spanish

The analysis developed in the preceding section has implications that extend beyond the specific case of Chilean Spanish. As shown, personal articles in this variety constitute a purely formal phenomenon: their presence introduces register and style-related restrictions associated to the innovative subgrammar, but encodes no meaning difference beyond these use-conditional effects. Therefore, any theory aiming to account for the expressive import of personal articles in other dialects must therefore address a comparative problem: why does the same surface configuration encode interpersonal proximity in those varieties but not in Chilean Spanish?

A range of analytical approaches could in principle address this comparative problem. One of them involves locating the source of the expressive content of the personal article within the narrow syntax, as proposed by Oggiani & Aguilar Guevara (2024). These authors adopt Longobardi’s (1994) N-to-D analysis for the internal structure of the DP: D is semantically expletive, and its phonological realization stems from the proper name not moving into D. In their proposal, however, interpersonal proximity does not originate within the DP itself. To derive it, they draw on Wiltschko’s (2014, 2021) *Universal Spine Hypothesis*: they assume that the grammar projects an interactional spine above the nominal domain. On this account, the DP is merged as the complement of a head $\text{Ground}_{\text{Spkr}}$, whose specifier corresponds to the speaker’s mental state. The presence of the expletive article triggers the positive valuation of a $[\text{ucoin}]$ feature on $\text{Ground}_{\text{Spkr}}$, which establishes a coincidence relation between

the speaker’s mental state and the referent of the proper name. The result is a reading involving interpersonal proximity toward the name’s referent.



As can be seen, the expressive content in Oggiani & Aguilar Guevara’s proposal does not reside in the article itself but in the (narrow) syntactic relationship between the expletive article and the interactional projection. Such an approach could in principle account for the different behavior of the Chilean Spanish data simply by positing that the personal article in this variety does not activate the interactional structure above the DP, so no interpersonal proximity interpretation arises.

Saab (2025a,b), on the other hand, advances a PF-based analysis of how the interpersonal proximity interpretation obtains. He argues that both bare names and names with personal articles share the same narrow syntactic derivation, namely the one represented here in (53b). The personal article form arises through an additional optional operation at PF: the insertion of a dissociated D morpheme above the complex head D formed by movement. However, since the two surface forms are identical at LF, the *Principle of Stylistic Meaning* applies.

(72) PRINCIPLE OF STYLISTIC MEANING (Saab 2025b)

Given a pair of abstract objects X and Y, if X and Y are not semantically distinguishable at LF, they are “semantically” distinguished at PF.

This principle shares the same intuition as *synonymy avoidance*, a well-known principle that demands that all contrasts in form also introduce a contrast in meaning (e.g., Clark 1987, Murphy 2003, Cann 2011). Thus, the same type of meaning dynamics that leads to distinguish *fiddle* from *violin* might be conspiring to distinguish between *el Carlos* and *Carlos*. Applied to the present case, the idea is that a personal name with a definite article must be semantically distinguished from its bare counterpart by a form-based *bias* that restricts its use to informal contexts in which the speaker stands in interpersonal proximity to the referent.

(73) PF-bias: $c \in CU(\text{ART} + \text{proper name})$ only if, in c , c_a is a participant in an informal register and is in interpersonal proximity with the referent of the proper name.

As can be seen, Saab’s principle of stylistic meaning provides both a rationale for the expressive distinction between truth-conditionally equivalent forms and a “slot”, i.e., the PF-bias, in which that distinction is encoded. The specific content of this expressive interpretation, however, is not derived

but stipulated: nothing in the system predicts that personal articles should be associated with interpersonal proximity rather than with any other expressive interpretation. A similar observation applies, at least in part, to Oggiani & Aguilar Guevara's (2024) analysis: while their framework derives that the meaning must be speaker-oriented and involve a relation between the speaker's mental state and the referent, it does not fully determine why that relation should be specifically one of interpersonal proximity.

This aspect of both proposals might simply be due to the fact that the interpersonal proximity interpretation is conventional, i.e., it is stored as part of the linguistic knowledge rather than derived from independent factors. This opens the possibility that what distinguishes the meaning of personal articles in the innovative subgrammar of Chilean Spanish speakers is that it simply lacks this convention. Thus, for instance, the PF-bias for the pattern in Chilean Spanish might be associated only with register and style-related use-conditions, which would account for the data discussed from (31) to (36). Further comparative work between the relevant varieties is needed to settle the issue.

It is worth highlighting one final aspect in which these proposals differ from the analysis developed here for Chilean Spanish: neither Oggiani & Aguilar Guevara (2024) nor Saab (2025a,b) posit a two-subgrammar architecture of the kind argued for in (70). The reasons differ in each case. For Oggiani & Aguilar Guevara, such an architecture seems simply unnecessary. Since they take personal articles to relate to a specific configuration of the interactional spine, the two forms of the personal name differ in their syntactic representation and at LF. The alternation between bare and determined names, therefore, is not a case of competition for use between LF-equivalent expressions, but a choice between two genuinely distinct grammatical objects. Since both forms are semantically distinguishable to begin with, there is no real optionality that would motivate appealing to subgrammar competition.

On the other hand, Saab (2025b) explicitly rejects the traditional Krochian (1989, 1994, 2001) assumption that a single grammar cannot generate doublets bearing register and expressivity-related meaning such as *Carlos* and *el Carlos*. His proposal is aimed to challenge this view: he treats the determined and bare forms of personal names as outputs of the same syntactic derivation. On his proposal, the expressive meaning of personal articles is, due to the principle in (72), a consequence of a single grammar generating two representations that are equivalent at LF.

The upshot is that, unlike what I have argued for Chilean Spanish, there is no case for a two-subgrammar architecture in the analysis of personal articles in other Spanish varieties. Two considerations set Chilean Spanish apart in this regard. The first is the one reviewed in the previous subsection: the clustering of the personal article with the placeholder *este* remains unmotivated within a unified grammatical system and thus supports the two-subgrammar division in (70). In the absence of comparable evidence from other varieties, the simpler single-grammar architectures assumed implicitly by Oggiani & Aguilar Guevara and explicitly by Saab remain adequate.

The second piece of evidence comes from the frequency facts reviewed in section 2.2: in Chilean Spanish, the personal article is not a marginal or occasionally deployed option, but the realization attested in the majority of tokens, at rates that far exceed those found in any other variety surveyed (e.g., De Mello 1992, Tieperman 2020, Hunt 2021). The magnitude of this contrast is itself suggestive of an architectural distinction between Chilean Spanish and the rest of the Spanish-speaking world: Chilean Spanish has two subgrammars for personal names, with the one introducing personal articles being the preferred one; other varieties simply exhibit marked and unmarked forms for personal names

within a single grammatical system.¹⁶

5 Concluding remarks

This paper has examined the distribution and interpretation of personal articles in Chilean Spanish. In other Spanish varieties, personal articles are commonly attributed expressive meanings associated with interpersonal proximity. The situation in Chilean Spanish, however, is different. Quantitative evidence shows that speakers of this variety produce personal articles at a significantly higher rate than speakers of other Spanish dialects, a fact that suggests that the phenomenon is not merely a pragmatic option. Moreover, acceptability judgments reveal that, unlike in other previously studied varieties, personal articles in Chilean Spanish do not function as anaphoric devices and do not encode interpersonal proximity.

To account for these facts, I have argued that speakers of Chilean Spanish are, in a sense, “diglossic”, and have internalized two separate subgrammars: a conservative pan-Hispanic one, which generates bare personal names following the Spanish norm, and an innovative Chilean one, in which personal names are systematically accompanied by an overt definite article. The two surface forms generated by these subgrammars are truth-conditionally equivalent and differ only in their use-conditional properties: the innovative form is subject to register restrictions that render it inappropriate in highly formal contexts. The difference between the two forms is therefore purely formal, with no semantic content attributable to the personal article beyond register marking. Whether this alternation is located in the narrow syntax or at PF remains an open question, but both implementations are compatible with the observed semantic equivalence of the two forms. The observed optionality of personal articles in the variety thus follows from the coexistence and competition of these two subgrammars.

Independent support for this proposal comes from the behavior of nominal placeholders. In both Rioplatense and Chilean Spanish, nominal placeholders that stand in for personal names pattern with the personal names of their respective variety: the Rioplatense placeholder *coso* surfaces without a definite article, while its Chilean counterpart *este* cannot function as a placeholder without one. Personal articles and the placeholder *este* thus form a cluster in Chilean Spanish, a pattern that is unexpected under a single-grammar account but follows naturally from the two-subgrammar analysis, since the rules governing the placeholder use of *este* belong to the innovative subgrammar on the present analysis.

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¹⁶I remain agnostic as to whether the two-subgrammar approach proposed for Chilean Spanish should be extended to register-related alternations more generally. The argument developed here is aimed at accounting for the properties and distribution of personal articles in this variety. Whether comparable data sets elsewhere call for competing subgrammars or for a single grammar seems far from obvious.

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